

Carrel.

The study workspace that turns your deadlines into a system. Drop in anything you read , PDFs, slides, docs, notes, transcripts , and Carrel plans your week, runs the spaced review, and keeps every answer honest with citations you can click and verify.

I built Carrel because I watched students use eight apps to study for one exam, miss the deadline anyway, and learn nothing they could prove. So I built one app that does the whole loop.

Studying is eight apps and a calendar that lies.

A second-year med student has 14 lecture PDFs, 6 textbook chapters, 200 highlights in Notion, an Anki deck someone shared on Reddit, three AI tools she pays for, and a final on Friday. None of them know about Friday. None of them tell her what to study tonight. She gets to Thursday at 11pm having studied the wrong material.

The deadline gap

No tool ties what you are reading today to what you owe on Friday. Calendars are passive; study apps are deadline-blind.

The format tax

Lectures are PDFs, slides are PPTX, summaries are Markdown, transcripts are docx, the syllabus is a website. Each tool owns one format and ignores the rest.

The trust gap

Every AI study tool fabricates. A student cannot ship a wrong answer to an exam. Verification has to happen in one click, every time.

The deadline is the unit of work. Everything else is in service of it.

Other tools start with the file (Notion), the highlight (Readwise), the question (ChatGPT), or the card (Anki). Carrel starts with Friday. The exam, the paper, the deliverable. From that anchor, every PDF you drop in, every concept you mark weak, every slot of free time on your calendar gets allocated automatically toward closing the gap. The student stops choosing what to study and starts trusting that the system already chose.

Plan first. Everything else feeds the plan.

Plan

Add a deadline. Carrel drafts the study schedule against your real calendar, picks tonight's session, surfaces the weakest concepts, and rebuilds when you fall behind. The home view, every day.

Library

Drop in anything: PDFs, slides (PPTX), Word docs, Markdown notes, Excel sheets, CSV data, plain text. Auto-grouped by subject. The format does not matter; the source does.

Sessions & Review

Spaced-repetition cards generated from your sources. Daily review queue tied to your deadlines, not a generic algorithm. Streak that means something.

Ask & Reader

When you need an answer, ask. Every claim cites the verbatim span; click the chip and Carrel flies you to the source. No fabrication, ever.

Click a citation chip.
The chip flies to the source span.
The page scrolls. The chunk pulses once.

420ms 60fps 1 click

total motion budget

WKWebView, no jank

to verify any claim

Demo this live. The deck cannot carry the wedge — the gesture does.

Three tailwinds converged in the last 12 months.

2025

Local LLMs cleared the bar

Llama 3.1 8B and Apple Intelligence ship quality good enough that an on-device free tier is no longer a downgrade.

2026

Privacy is a buying criterion

EU AI Act enforcement and a wave of US state laws have moved "my data left my device" from a footnote to a procurement objection.

NOW

AI-tool fatigue is real

Knowledge workers churn through 8+ AI tools a year. The winner is the one that fits the existing workflow, not the one with the biggest model.

Path to \$1M ARR via the student who has Friday.

8,300 paying student subscribers at \$10/mo. That is the proof point this round funds. Students are the wedge because they have hard deadlines, low tool inertia, viral sharing inside cohorts, and an existing \$50/mo spend on Notion + Quizlet + ChatGPT they would consolidate to one app.

SEGMENT	WEDGE	PRICE	WHY NOW
University students	Deadlines + universal ingest + grounded Ask	\$10/mo (.edu)	Cohort virality, semester-paced; primary segment.
Pro learners (MBA, residency, bar/CFA prep)	Same engine, higher willingness	\$20/mo	Outcomes-bound, time-poor, already pay \$200+/mo on prep.
Study groups & tutors	Shared library, shared deadlines	\$8/seat/mo	Year 2 motion. Pulls in via student power-users.

US/EU/AU full-time students alone: 25M+. We do not need a percentage point. We need 0.03% of them.

No one ships this combination today.

	DEADLINE PLANNING	UNIVERSAL INGEST	SPACED REVIEW	CITED ANSWERS
Notion AI	No	No	No	No
Quizlet / Anki	No	Partial	No	No
NotebookLM	No	No	Partial	No
ChatGPT Study Mode	No	No	No	No
Carrel	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

The category is "AI study tools." Every competitor owns one verb: take notes, drill cards, summarize a doc, answer a question. None plan toward a deadline. None compound across the semester. By month 3, a Carrel user has weeks of weak-concept history, deadline-tied review sessions, and a calendar that knows their schedule. Switching costs the semester.

Shipped, measured, in production.

9

Features end-to-end

Library, Reader, Ask, Sessions, Review Queue, Search, Concepts, Plan, Onboarding tour. Each has its own animation contract and test suite.

710

Tests passing today

346 frontend (Vitest), 364 backend (pytest), including an 18-probe adversarial prompt-injection suite. CI green every commit.

47 KB

Entry JS bundle, gzipped

Code-split lazy routes. 60fps citation flight in WKWebView. The whole UI fits in a single network round-trip.

100%

Local data plane

SQLite, sqlite-vec, fastembed. Zero network at boot. Anthropic API only on user-initiated Ask. The free tier never leaves the device.

What's real, what's next.

Real today

- Production-grade macOS app. End-to-end loop: ingest, plan, study, review, ask, cite.
- Universal ingest live: PDF, DOCX, PPTX, Markdown, plain text, CSV, Excel.
- Plan view with deadline-aware scheduling against the user's real calendar.
- Solo-built; design system, docs, audit trail, 710 tests in the repo.

Next 90 days

- Closed beta to 50 student design partners across 5 universities.
- Android via Capacitor wrap of the existing web bundle. Same codebase, two platforms.
- Stripe live behind the .edu tier. First 100 paying students as the open-signup gate.
- Audio and EPUB ingest. Image OCR for textbook photos.

Honest: zero paying users today. The ask funds the path to first paid revenue, not the scale-up after it.

One operator. Time to compound.

[**Founder name**], previously [prior shipped product]. Built Carrel solo because [domain reason — why you, specifically, are the one to do this]. Hiring engineer #2 with this round to own iPad and iOS.

THE ASK			
ROUND	CAP	RUNWAY	KILL METRIC
\$750K SAFE	\$6M post	12 months	1,000 Pro subs
Use of funds: founder salary, one senior engineer, design contractor at 20 hrs/week, Anthropic API for free-trial periods during launch, infrastructure, EU privacy + legal, modest launch budget. If we miss 1,000 paying Pro subs by month 12, we do not raise seed.			

CLOSE

If you have a deadline,
you will not close this app.

Try it: [carrel.app](#) · Demo: [\[your calendar link\]](#) · [\[your email\]](#)